REWRITING THE KE

THE CONGRESS HOLDING ON TO ONE OF ITS LAST BASTIONS, THE LEFT LOOKING FOR RESURRECTION AND THE BJP SEARCHING FOR A BREACH IN THE WALLS. WHICH WAY WILL KERALA TURN?

BY JEEMON JACOB *in Kochi*



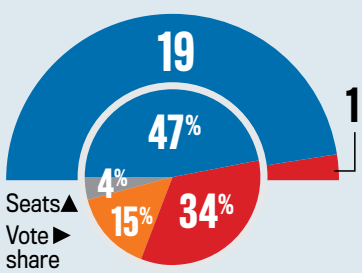
GLANCED AT THROUGH A TELESCOPE from Lutyens' Delhi, the tiny planet of Kerala can trigger bouts of incomprehension. An outlier in spatial terms, it enacts that distance from the mainland every which way—including those cussed indices of political behaviour. Its slim corpus of 20 seats amounts to a piffling 3.7 per cent of the Lok Sabha, but they crackle with *too much* democracy. Indeed, if not for recalcitrant Tamil Nadu next door, Kerala might seem to comport itself with all the swag of that single Gaulish village which stood up to the Romans. So a sliver or three of that land carries as much symbolic weight as it did when, in mythic history, Vamana sought the exact same thing from King Mahabali.

Those with a perceptive eye for nuance may remember: Prime Minister Narendra Modi's 2019 victory speech had made it plain that a certain absence rankled, explicitly marking Kerala as a remaining frontier. The party's eagerness to break a couple of coconuts here has only become keener since—and the fight scrappier. On April 5, controversially enough, Doordarshan telecast *The Kerala Story*. A tacky piece of cinematic agit-prop with caricatured villainy and oodles of reproach may seem an odd way to woo a people, but it did register the state's prickly presence in the national consciousness. Kerala was on someone's mind.

Rahul Gandhi's Wayanad candidacy highlights both the national connect and aloofness at once. As if to say, 'Whatever Kerala is, it is *not* UP—it will understand'. Even in its low tide of 2019, Kerala had been a safe sanctuary from the saffron floodplains of the north for the Congress. But coming around for another round of rejuvenating ayurvedic *sukha chikitsa*, it finds the air a touch more complex and charged. One reason is the BJP's ingress. Modi posters saturate the public

INVERSION THERAPY

LOK SABHA 2019
(Total seats: 20)



Within UDF, Congress had the biggest share of 15 seats